

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1997-02-04

dear bahá'í friends,

with the four year plan successfully launched and the believers in all parts of the world engaged in the energetic pursuit of its objectives, the universal house of justice has decided that it is timely to inform you of the state of the international funds of the faith. we have been asked to convey the following to you.

As you are well aware, the major focus of attention for the past several years has been the Arc projects fund, with the friends summoned to provide financial support for the largest project ever undertaken by the worldwide bahá'í community. The response of the followers of bahá'u'lláh in every part of the planet has been magnificent, resulting in a sacrificial outpouring of contributions of a magnitude far beyond that ever previously achieved. The house of justice was pleased to be able to announce in its ríḡván 1996 message the accomplishment of the Three year plan goal of 74 million u.S. dollars for that fund.

it appears that the contribution of ten million dollars each year until the end of the century for the Arc projects fund, now being made by the believers in response to the call of the house of justice set out in its letter of 20 june 1995, will be sufficient to meet the needs for completion of this enterprise, although there always remains the possibility of unforeseen disturbances in the years ahead modifying this projection. The planning and execution of the vast undertaking on mount carmel is being carried out with careful attention to economy, without compromising the high standards of construction befitting the edifices and terraces on the mountain of god.

even though there has been a striking increase in the total amount received at the world center during the past several years, the level of contributions to the bahá'í international fund itself has diminished during that period, in which attention was centered on a strenuous endeavor to meet the needs of the Arc projects fund. in reaction to this diminution of support to the bahá'í international fund, the house of justice enforced stringent

economy at the bahá'í world center and also felt compelled to limit the funds available to meet the needs of the faith in other parts of the world.240.1

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message from The Universal House of Justice

558The bahá'í international fund provides assistance to bahá'í communities in those countries where the believers lack the means to exploit adequately the opportunities for the expansion of the faith and for the diffusion of its spirit. As the cause of god moves irresistibly forward in every sphere of its manifold activities, propelled by the mysterious spiritual forces which are advancing humanity through a turbulent age of transition, the calls made on it can only increase. The fund will be required to support the development of human resources, an indispensable element of the rapidly advancing process of entry by troops. with the emergence of new opportunities to increase the influence of the faith on the affairs of humanity, the necessary means must be provided to expand the work of the bahá'í international community at the united Nations, the representation of the faith at international conferences of non-governmental organizations, and the number of social and economic development projects scattered over the surface of the planet.

The work at the world center, which is carried out with the support of the bahá'í international fund, includes the preservation and classification of the Sacred Texts, and the administrative functions performed here to meet the needs of a worldwide community expanding in both the magnitude and scope of its activities. An important aspect of this work is that of restoring and maintaining the holy places, providing facilities for pilgrims and an increasing number of visitors, and caring for the gardens which beautify the environs of the holy Shrines. with the expansion of high-density urban development in the holy land, it is essential that properties be acquired close to the Shrines and other holy places, to protect them from disturbance; the favorable conditions now developing for such property acquisitions may not recur until the far distant future, and a substantial proportion of the resources of the fund will be required for this purpose in the years immediately ahead.

fully aware of the sacrificial response of the believers to every call ad-

dressed to them in the past, the house of justice will continue to guide
the friends in proceeding energetically along every avenue available for the advancement of
the faith and its interests. it will do so in full confidence
that the dearly loved followers of bahá'u'lláh will remain ever conscious of
their privilege and duty to attend to the needs of the cause, and will not
suffer the onward march of the faith to be retarded through an inadequacy
of resources. it will offer its supplications in the holy Shrines that their
consecrated endeavors may attract the blessings of their beloved.
with loving bahá'í greetings,
for Department of the Secretariat^{240.5}
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1996–2000 • The Four Year Plan
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Passing of Hushang Ahdieh,
Former Continental Counselor

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]